of the people of Pakistan. Their strategy worked for quite some time and they enjoyed public sympathy.

However, the suicide attack on Islamabad Marriot Hotel on 25 September 2008 triggered public anger against them as Baitullah Mehsud claimed the responsibility of this action. It was the turning point when people started condemning them (Christain Science Monitor, 2008). As mentioned, these anti-TTP sentiments were reinforced by the footage of flogging of a teenage girl, Chand Bibi, by the Swat TTP, shown in Pakistani TV channels on 2 April 2009.

Interestingly, the majority of Pakistanis, who were ambivalent about TTP's role even after the devastating suicide attacks, reacted unanimously in denouncing the perpetrators of flogging. This unanimity enabled the army to carry out the successful operation *Rah-e-Rast* against the Swati TTP in 2009.

A few months before, a questionnaire conducted on the educated people of Lahore during February 2009 revealed interesting trends: 97 per cent considered TTP and Al Qaeda in FATA a threat to Pakistan; 97 per cent thought their activities could spread in other areas; 97 per cent considered TTP's claim to impose Islamic laws as illegal and in violation of the Constitution of Pakistan and 96 per cent would not like to vote for the religious-political parties of Pakistan.

Interaction with people from the lower strata of society in Lahore, Islamabad, Karachi and other cities showed that they also do not support terrorists and their activities. They abhorred the terrorists because they were a threat to the safety of their families and children. People did not show sympathy for terrorists. Only their confusion about the identity of terrorists, created due to confused policies of the government, made them ambivalent. They were puzzled by the official statements whether TTP carried out the terrorist attacks or Indian or foreign forces were behind these activities as was stated by the Interior Minister and even by the Punjab Law Minister after every terrorist attack.

People took time to start distinguishing between the TTP and Afghan Taliban. Especially after major terrorist incidents, the majority developed a disliking for the former, at least outside KP. However, the sentiments for the latter were not bitter, as they were not considered a threat to Pakistan. Their fight within Afghanistan, against the Afghan government backed by the US and International forces, was considered